



hockey player," she says.

High standards

The tough love, Kanika admits, may have been necessary. "Everyone thinks it's easy for me because everything was charted out for me. But it's hard growing up with a lot of eyes on you. There's constant pressure and expectation. I always feel I have to perform twice as well to justify my place," she says.

Those high standards haven't faded even though Kanika is now one of the pillars of the junior team. "She's proud of me but keeps telling me I need to work harder. She says it's not enough to just be part of the team or go to a World Cup — I have to win a medal too. She keeps pushing me," Kanika says.

Try as she might, Pritam admits it's hard for Kanika to develop the same mindset she once had. "I can't expect Kanika to be as mentally tough as I was. We're playing in two very different generations. When I started, there was little media support or exposure. We had to fight not just on the field, but at home and in the village for the chance to play. I got married very young and had both my children during my career. Now things are far more professional. There are leagues, and players are better off financially. I sometimes tell her that no matter how bad things

get for her, players from my time had to pick up women's hockey from zero," she says.

Kanika, Pritam says with a smile, is a lot softer. "Kanika plays the same centre-forward position I did, so I can compare us. She's physically stronger than I was at her age and uses that strength well. She's quick with the ball and always looking for chances to score. I used to keep my head down too much. But for all her skill, she isn't as tough mentally. She cries quickly! Her heart is a little weak. I was more of a fighter because I had no choice. If I'd been even a little weaker, I wouldn't have gone anywhere," she says.

Harder workers

Pritam believes players of her generation valued opportunity differently. "Getting a chance to play was a blessing, so we took it more seriously. Players today get more exposure and better facilities, which is great. But maybe we were more dedicated. We constantly worked on our personal technique. What I notice as a coach now is that players rarely do anything beyond their regular training sessions," she says.

Kanika agrees but says her mother's discipline drives her. "I don't think I've seen anyone as dedicated to hockey as her. Even after retiring from international hockey, she

Inspiring legacy: On her hostel wall, Kanika has pasted pictures of her mother, whose journey in Indian hockey keeps her inspired every day.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

played departmental matches for years. One day, a friend called to say, 'Do you know your mom just made a full-length dive and scored a goal?' I was shocked! I'd heard stories of her comeback after having me — when people thought she'd slowed down, she challenged the fastest girl in the team to a race and beat her. Even now, when we play each other, she's really tough to beat. That's the fighting spirit I want," says Kanika.

Bigger dreams

Mother and daughter differ not only in temperament but also in ambition. Kanika's dream is to play in the Los Angeles Olympics three years from now. For Pritam, the Olympics remained a dream unfulfilled.

"It's always the case that every new generation builds on the previous one. For me, the Olympics were something I could never compete in. When I was young, I didn't even know about them. My goal was simply to play for India. For Kanika, the Olympics feel possible. She'll have to work very hard, but I'm happy she's aiming that high," she says. That sense of continuity is how Pritam sees her own mother's role, too.

"When I was young, it was seen as a scandal that I was being allowed to play. My father, uncle, and the people in our village wanted me to be married early. It was my mother, an uneducated woman who had never left the village, who stood up for me. She never played hockey herself, but if it wasn't for her, neither Kanika nor I would have been hockey players," she says.

Having come this far, Pritam is clear she doesn't want the Siwach hockey line to end with Kanika. "I've already told my son that I expect him to get married in three years. I want a grandchild I can start teaching hockey to! By then, I hope I'll have less work at my academy and can focus all my attention on that child!" she laughs.